



Off the board: Arjun Erigaisi for Gen.G Esports and Nihal Sarin for S8UL Esports faced off in the opening round, with the former walking away with the win. **Right:** Magnus Carlsen, playing for Team Liquid, defended his title.

ESPORTS WORLD CUP MEDIA/ESPORTS FOUNDATION

out in the lower-bracket playoffs by Erigaisi.

"I think this format really has been waiting for chess for a while. You see, as soon as people started having internet in their homes, they started playing chess online," Carlsen said after winning the title. "A lot of the best chess players migrated to, not chiefly, but partly, online as early as 1995. It's been coming, and I'm very happy that we're here."

Nakamura also advocated for chess to remain part of the tournament. "I think that as far as chess goes as a game, it definitely looks better when it's contrasted against other games or sports, as

opposed to a standalone. So I think chess as an individual tournament, I don't think it is really that spectacular or interesting. It doesn't seem all that great," Nakamura said.

"When chess is here with all these other esports, and it's part of a bigger competition, it really shines. For the chess ecosystem, it's very good. Even if you finish 16th, I think it's \$50,000, which is a lot more than most players will make in a year, unfortunately. So that's very good. Also, because of the team standings, there are a lot of sponsors."

The Esports World Cup this year saw players as young as 15 become champions. But above all, the tournament showed what really makes a World Cup — not necessarily the sport itself, but the people who give it meaning: the players and fans, along with rivalries, heartbreaks and shared joy. Perhaps that is what Paris answered, loud and clear.

(The writer was in Paris at the invitation of Esports Foundation)

